

Not factual and lacking objectivity. It's negative stuff, I asked Patrice to rewrite, but nothing, so below my response.

1 Toxic Department

The main criticism is I don't get along and keep on suing people. I'm actually shocked they¹ bring it up, they should be ashamed and keep it quiet, but since they brought it up, let me respond. What happened here is that Gloria offered \$5k for a workshop for her staff, I did the workshop, she didn't pay, so I told her I'll have to sue, then she paid. End of story. Why even bring this up? What did I do wrong? I'd be wrong if I didn't sue. And no hard feelings, stuff happens, let's move on.² Then suing Mike: he signed merit pay evaluation that's non-factual, it said I "underperform" in "research", while I can prove I over-perform (see later towards the end under research)—again looks like a clear case to me to sue. Why not? Any reasonable person would do the same.³

I could elaborate more⁴ but again why you even bring this up? If anything it puts Gloria in bad light, not me. What did you think would happen here?⁵

Patrice blames toxic department on me—it was toxic long before I threatened to sue. Suing one person has little to do with other persons, if anything at all. And suing is a good way to seek fairness/justice, which we badly lack in DPPA—if anything I should get award, not be blamed.

"Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair."—yes! It was a poor dissertation. I did my job. What's strange is that Paul kicked me out of the committee, as opposed to fix the dissertation.

Teaching evaluation. Paul got this idea that he is my mentor and that I need his advice. He doesn't know much about my research area and giving me bad advice (instrumental variables etc). I'm trying to steer away from him, doesn't work, he needs to force his way. Paul doesn't take it well that I don't listen to his bad research advice. He retaliates by forcing himself to do evaluation of my class and gives me bad evaluation.⁶

¹By "they" I mean Gloria and Patrice—as far as I can tell Gloria really runs the department, not Patrice.

²If I made stuff up, then she probably would not pay, but she did pay. But if there are any slightest doubts on what happened, please let me know and let's dig deeper here.

³Here I actually backed off for 2 reasons—I had a good conversation with the dean who convinced me it's not necessary to sue, and 2) I felt bad for Mike because I'm pretty sure it wasn't him behind this fake evaluation—it was most likely Gloria behind the scenes, Mike just signed it. But keep on pushing me and I will sue. We can go that way. It's ridiculous you even bring this up. Finally, Patrice says I threatened to sue 3 people. No. I think she means one email I sent to her, but I didn't mean her, but Mike who signed the evaluation, and effectively Gloria who was most likely behind the scenes. So it's really just about one person, Gloria.

⁴"Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty"—I fit right in, everyone is. "threatened to sue 3 faculty members"—no, just one, just Gloria, but she settled so we are all good from my side. No hard feelings. Gloria also seemed to have made Mike sign poor merit pay evaluation for me, so I had to threaten lawsuit there, but it's all about Gloria behind the scenes. And Patrice misunderstood one email, it wasn't about her, but about Gloria. "His threats have strained working relationships in the department."—how? Gloria wasn't talking to me anyway—I haven't strained any relationship with Gloria—it never existed. "This makes it extremely difficult to for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors."—I don't think me suing Gloria has anything to do with me working with others, especially junior folks. If anything people should appreciate me seeking justice. There's actually just one junior person, Cint, and we do get along, Clint invited me to be on his grant, we got it, and will be doing reseaaarch together. It's opposite, it's most difficult to work with full professors in DPPA, not junior.

⁵I guess it was meant to scare me or something or make me more docile and do what I'm told, like later under Service Patrice says I should work for free for Gloria' and Steve's centers if I understood correctly. But no, I won't be pushed around. But while I have my boundaries, at the same time, I am super friendly, I study happiness after all. Come on DPPA let's move on and let's get along, let's have a beer and smoke a cigar together:)

⁶Another reason for not having Paul evaluate my teaching: he had this terrible PhD qualifying exam that was counterproductive for students, so I had at a time a political action/petition with students going on against Paul's cheerished exam. I knew he was really angry with me upending his favorite exam, so I went to Patrice and explained that there is conflict of interest: I am rallying up students against Paul's favorite exam, and you have Paul evaluate my teaching. Patrice brushed it off. Patrice could have done evaluation herself, could have chosen another associate professor. Actually I did find a great evaluator myself, Bill Fitzgerald from Teaching Matters. Yet another reason I gave to Patrice: the class I was teaching was outside of Paul's expertise, and you'll see in attached evaluation Paul didn't understand much of the class. Last but not least, I wouldn't be sure 100% from all of this that Paul was indeed retailaiting. But I did confront him after evaluation, I met him in person and told him I felt it was like retaliation, that he was going after me. His face went red. I actually didn't expect it! I thought maybe there was some benign reason. I mean we're all human, Paul is a good person in general I guess, but come on, really? This is the kind of stuff we have going on in DPPA.

2 Teaching

In teaching section Patrice cherry picks negative student evaluations out of mostly positive ones. To be sure, I did take those into account, fixed up Canvas, organized better. I do take teaching seriously.

"Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems indifferent to the needs of DPPA students."—fundamentally, there is a cross-department conflict here: Patrice does not want me to teach data science students. But data science is my strength and we have a new data science program that I am contributing to—I don't think I should be penalized for supporting another program. Or maybe I am in the wrong department, I'd be very happy to move to another department, I'm pretty sure DPPA is the least happy department on campus. The good news now for even most coding-averse DPPA students is AI that can write the code for them.

3 Service

"I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department"—I heard that 3 years ago when department denied support for my promotion, so I asked what can I do for the department. I did everything I was asked to do, and more, I did extra things I wasn't asked (see CV for my service details), in fact I went to Patrice every semester to check on service. Last year, I have a date somewhere, Patrice said "Adam, your service is good." No comments.

Just briefly to respond to the things Patrice says I should be doing. "There are opportunities to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:"

- "Advising doctoral students" "Guiding dissertations and working collaboratively with other committee members"—that's funny! I supervise 5. The departmental recommendation is 3. So there is no thanks for going above and beyond, and apparently I don't do enough. In addition I am supervising master theses in Data Science, and I do many independent studies—in fact I think I'm doing more than anybody else in the department here. Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies.
- "Assisting the department with: data dashboards, graduation rates for students, data collection"—that sounds like institutional research, not a part of my job description.
- "assisting with data from affiliated centers"—Patrice seems to ask that I work for Gloria's and Steve's centers apparently for free. I don't believe it's in my job description. However, I'm always happy to do paid consulting. (Gloria would have to pay upfront to avoid problems from the past).
- "Workshops for PhD Students"—I do those occasionally, e.g., "Publish or Perish—how to publish" and did GIS workshop. I was doing regularly brown bags, but Patrice told me we don't need them, now apparently she changed her mind, so happy to do those again.
- "Data Mentoring"—I don't know what that means, I guess that's what I do in my classes and with students that I advise, I don't see where else I should be doing it.

"he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used."—Paul did the same, i.e., used published papers in exam questions. I might have occasionally used/re-used questions from the past—my understanding is that it's fine as long as it is not all of the questions and not from prior year. "He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee."—I am efficient and productive.

4 Research

My favorite section. "There is room for improvement"—wow. I was asked not to compare, so no names, just overall department stats.

Research impact or visibility is commonly measured with citations, and I am the most cited person in the department, by large margin. As of May 11 2026, I'm cited exactly 2x the second best person in the department this year.

Quantity of research output is measured at [researchwithrutgers.com](https://www.researchwithrutgers.com)—both at research units/department level and employee level. The department (research unit: Graduate School, Camden: Public Policy and Administration) has 10 employees.⁷ Over the years 2019-2022⁸ the 10 employees of the department have produced 37 research outputs,⁹ out of which 17 were mine,¹⁰ i.e., I have produced about half of the 10 person unit's output.¹¹

2023-May 2026, the department has produced 33 outputs, out of which 13 are mine—I have been burdened with unfair amount of service over past 3 years, but still I have produced 40% of the department's output.

Visibility (and arguably quality and competitiveness) of the research output can be measured as Impact Factor (IF). As far as I can tell from quick search, there are only 2 people in this 10-person department that consistently publish in high impact journals, I am one of them. Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1.

And the department chair tells me "there is room for improvement." I would refrain from further comments to end it on a positive note. It's time for new blood and leadership change in DPPA. I would like to volunteer to be a department chair. This department can do well.

5 Appendix: Paul's teaching evaluation and my response

⁷<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/persons/>

⁸I took these from my merit pay which I wrote Nov15 2023.

⁹<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications>

¹⁰<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/persons/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/publications/>

¹¹Of course, the measure is crude and simplistic as it doesn't differentiate research output's length and quality. Still, it is remarkable that over 4 years one person has produced as much as other 9 people. And on quality, too, as measured by Impact Factor of journals, there are only 2 people in the department publishing in high impact journals, I am one of them.

Rutgers University-Camden
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Faculty Peer Evaluation of Classroom Teaching

Course:

- 56:219:521 DATA VISUALIZATION (dat sci)
- 56:824:728 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)
- 56:834:653 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)

Instructor: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn **Date Evaluated:** April 3, 2025

Note: Given the long time elapsed since the class observation, I supplemented my notes by watching the class video.

1. Subject of Class:

1) visualization techniques for data clustering, e.g. dendrograms and k-means scatterplots, 2) annotation of graphs using matplotlib, 3) “flipped classroom” to respond to student questions about a problem set.

2. Relevance of the subject to the course:

The content was appropriate to a course on data visualization, touching on important methods for representing clusters and relationships in data.

3. A. Was an assignment made: Yes _____ No ☒

Although no new assignment was introduced during the session, students appeared engaged with an assignment from the prior week and came prepared to discuss it.

B. Were students prepared: Yes ☒ No _____

4. Clarity of the ideas presented:

The description of the class as given to the students:

[apr3] clustering

a bit similar to previous scatterplots; clustering is about grouping / finding patterns, and very much data sciency!

we only scratch the surface here--just few popular vis for clustering;
i don't cover here the method, algorithms etc

Adam worked systematically through the material, alternating between code demonstrations in an online notebook and examples. The examples were presented clearly, but the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. For example, the class could have explored more explicitly when to use a dendrogram versus a scatterplot with k-means clustering. For another, an “elbow plot” was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes.

While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material.

5. Manner of delivery:

Adam put students at ease and was very responsive to student questions. He made good use of examples, both simple examples using a small dataset followed by more complete examples using graphics from published papers.

6. Effective use of teaching aide(s), if they apply:

Rather than a whiteboard or PowerPoint slides, Adam used an online coding notebook, an environment for writing and executing code. This is an appropriate format given the material and the emphasis on coding. However, the notebook’s structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing.

7. Student participation: The students were engaged throughout and asked appropriate questions. Adam had a good rapport with the students. When students sought deeper conceptual explanations (e.g., how clustering algorithms work), the responses could have gone beyond general descriptions to help students better understand the mechanics and assumptions of these techniques.

8: Other comments:

The syllabus and class notes would benefit from more careful organization and editing. Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program.

More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully.

Adam’s course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning

environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn *how* to make various chart but not *why* certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively.

Paul A. Jorgensen

Visitor: _____

Date: 11/11/2025 Instructor: Bob Olin-Kay Date: _____
nov21 2025

Acceptance or comments:

The evaluation was helpful as it made me realize that my html bullet points didn't render and thus obscured readability; and it got me thinking about spending less time on code as AI takes over. Other than that the evaluation was unhelpful. I would like to raise several issues so that we can do better in the future.

Paul does not teach Python or data visualization. Neither does he use Python in his research. I was arguing to have someone else evaluate my teaching. I even found a replacement to do evaluation. Then I can't get the evaluation for 7 months (class was in April, I get evaluation in November) despite multiple emails and reminders. And then evaluation is mostly unhelpful as outlined below with my inline responses.

"the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. "

It's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"an "elbow plot" was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes."

That's the whole point of the "elbow plot" to tell the number of groups. Again, it's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material."

No. There is a reference to a specific chapter: "and especially machine learning ch:
<https://jakevdp.github.io/PythonDataScienceHandbook/05.00-machine-learning.html>"

"the notebook's structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the

material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing."

There are not only section headings, but there are 3 levels of them: chapters, sections, and sub-sections (and I even police this in students' assignments—I take points off if students don't use sections).

"Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program."

I was trying to discuss and get a sense of what Paul means here but I wasn't able to get detailed or specific information. As far as I can tell it's about writing style: Paul is traditional and formal. And I'm quite the opposite: modern, straightforward, and informal.

My materials have a clear structure and consistent format. I actually have a specific philosophy here to be straightforward and informal. I follow Zinnser's "On Writing Well: The Essential Guide to Mastering Nonfiction Writing and Effective Communication." For instance: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it." I was asking Paul for reference to his style, but I didn't get any.

I even wrote a paper on cluttered and ornamented grandiose prose in social science as compared to natural science: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>

So called social science "professional presentation" in writing can typically actually obscure meaning and communication. Again, following Zinnser, the goal should be simplicity and readability.

Per "high standards of our program"--i think my teaching has a good standard, e.g., my current students publish in good journals: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=6

And, what do we mean by "high standards of our program"? Is it formal traditional writing? Does such writing translate into desired outcomes, i.e. communication and learning? (especially in methods/coding classes). These are ever more relevant questions as we are increasingly over-burdened by information. Clarity, simplicity, and readability seem a way to go.

"More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully. Adam's course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn how to make various chart but not why certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively."

These were covered in the course earlier. The class was geared towards the students, not towards the visitation, i.e. the visited Apr3 class was not self-contained, it did not include important elements included in other classes.

I did reach out to Paul to discuss, build bridges, and understand each other better. We had 2 discussions, somewhat helpful, but still I was not able to get enough details and specificity. I got a sense that it is time to wrap up, hence my lengthy response above. For the future, I am hoping we can agree to disagree and work out constructive compromises.

The evaluation was also helpful in a sense that I watched the class video and noted I could have had a little more eye contact and walk around more and be less on the monitor. But again as outlined above most of the evaluation is unhelpful--I hope in the future we can be more constructive. I am excited to discuss and collaborate on teaching. I think we could focus more on teaching.

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